caste-based politics, convinced of the enduring strength of an RJD-JD(U) alliance, his son is focusing on a more inclusive voter base.

Tejaswi's 2020 campaign showcased his ability to transcend the RJD's traditional Muslim-Yadav base, winning 39 per cent votes in the 144 seats it contested. Now, buoyed by his partial success in drawing Kushwaha voters—Nitish's staunch supporters—into the RJD fold during the Lok Sabha election, Tejaswi has doubled down on his outreach efforts. His recent pre-poll promise to launch a gender-centric

THE DIVERGENCE BETWEEN LALU AND TEJASWI'S PUBLIC STANCES HINTS AT A CALCULATED DUAL STRATEGY RATHER THAN A DIFFERENCE OF OPINION

scheme—Mai Behan Maan Yojana—for a monthly cash transfer of Rs 2,500 to women mirrors similar initiatives that have reaped rich electoral dividends in Maharashtra and Jharkhand. With women's turnout in Bihar steadily climbing—59.39 per cent in the 2024 Lok Sabha polls, compared to 53.28 per cent for men—this strategy aims to dismantle Nitish's longstanding rapport with this crucial constituency.

Nitish, on his part, has ruled out the possibility of quitting the NDA, terming his two short-lived alliances with the RJD-Congress combine as a "mistake". But his career epitomises political adaptability, as he has been navigating the shifting sands of Bihar's political landscape with a supreme survivor's instinct. The road to 2025 promises to be a gripping battle of strategy and ambition, where alliances may shift and loyalties could once again be tested. ■

DIGITAL PERSONAL DATA PROTECTION

KEEPING PRIVACY PARAMOUNT

The draft rules unveiled by the Centre under the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023, are set to reshape digital behaviour, access and data privacy for all Indians

By Kaushik Deka | *Graphic by* TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

WHAT THE KEY RULES ARE

INFORMED CONSENT: The rules now require apps to explain in simple language what data they'll collect and why—like your location for curated playlists in case of music apps. No more hidden clauses in fine print

PARENTAL CONSENT FOR MINORS: If anyone aged under 18 years wants to create an account on, say, a gaming app, the parent must provide a verifiable consent

CONSENT MANAGERS In case you have shared data with an e-commerce website, you can use this tool to revoke permissions if you are no longer comfortable with how your data is being used

STRONGER SECURITY: Firms are now obligated to implement advanced security measures. For instance, a shopping app must encrypt your payment data and track access logs to detect unauthorised access

IMMEDIATE BREACH ALERT If your personal data is compromised, firms must notify you promptly with actionable steps

DATA RETENTION AND ERASURE Data fiduciaries* can no longer hoard your data indefinitely. So, if you stop using a food delivery app, it must delete your data after three years unless legally required to retain it

LOCALISATION Your personal data is safer within Indian borders. So, a health app storing medical records will have to comply with government guidelines if it wants to transfer this data to a server abroad

PROTECTIONS FOR CHILDREN'S DATA: For educational apps, tracking and monitoring of children's behaviour is restricted to safety or educational purposes. So, a school app can monitor attendance but cannot sell this data to advertisers

TRANSPARENCY Suppose you're curious about how a streaming platform uses your viewing history, you'll now find easy-to-understand policies and contacts for queries

ACCOUNTABILITY Data fiduciaries must document and audit their processes regularly. For instance, a financial institution must ensure its algorithms for approving loans don't discriminate with any user

**A person or entity that determines how personal data is processed, stored and used*